

Obelisks and Royal Tombs of Aksum

Massive monolithic stelae standing among the ruins of the ancient capital of the Kingdom of Aksum

The city of Aksum, in the present-day Tigray region of Ethiopia, was the center of a powerful civilization that flourished from the 1st to the 8th centuries. Numerous monuments and buildings from all periods of its history have survived, but undoubtedly the most impressive are the giant stelae, popularly known as obelisks—although they do not have the characteristic pyramidal cap of a true obelisk—which date from the 3rd and 4th centuries. These are arranged in two sites: the Northern Stelae Park, with the nearby tombs of the 6th-century King Kaleb and his son, King Gebre Meskel; and the smaller Gudit Stelae Park.

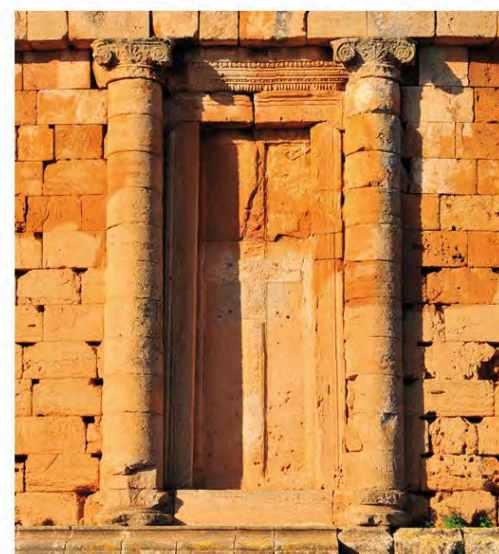
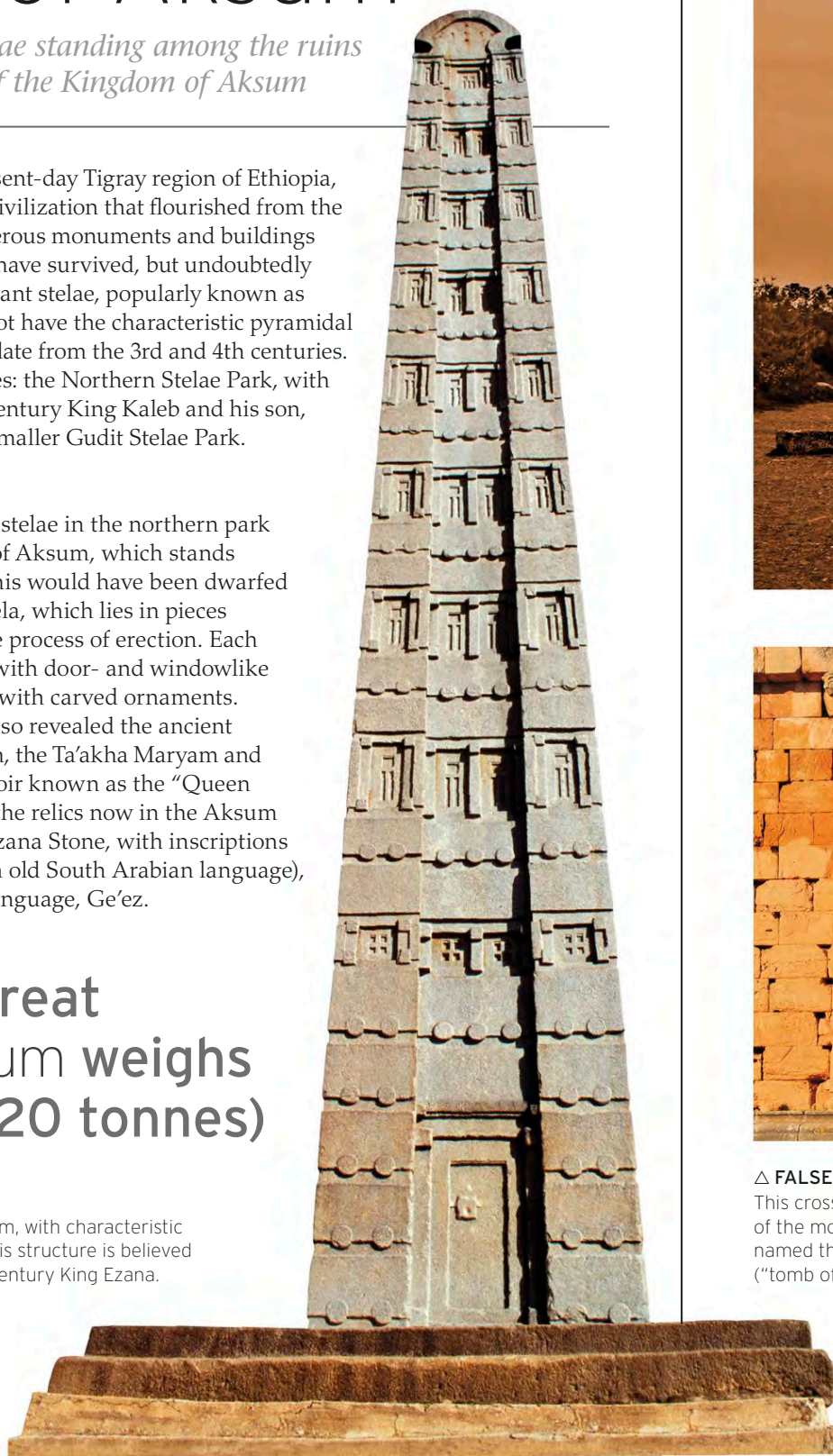
Ruins at Aksum

The collection of hundreds of stelae in the northern park is dominated by the Obelisk of Aksum, which stands 81 ft (24.6 m) high, but even this would have been dwarfed by the 109-ft (33-m) Great Stela, which lies in pieces where it fell, apparently in the process of erection. Each stela is decoratively sculpted with door- and windowlike panels, and many are topped with carved ornaments. Excavations at Aksum have also revealed the ancient megalithic tomb of King Bazen, the Ta'akha Maryam and Dungur palaces, and a reservoir known as the "Queen of Sheba's Bath"; and among the relics now in the Aksum museum is the 4th-century Ezana Stone, with inscriptions in ancient Greek, Sabaean (an old South Arabian language), and the Classical Ethiopian language, Ge'ez.

The fallen Great Stela in Aksum weighs 573 tons (520 tonnes)

▷ KING EZANA'S STELA

The largest unbroken stela in Aksum, with characteristic false window and door carvings, this structure is believed to mark the burial site of the 4th-century King Ezana.



△ FALSE DOOR

This cross shape inscribed on a false door of the monument led to it mistakenly being named the *Tombeau de la Chrétienne* ("tomb of the Christian woman").